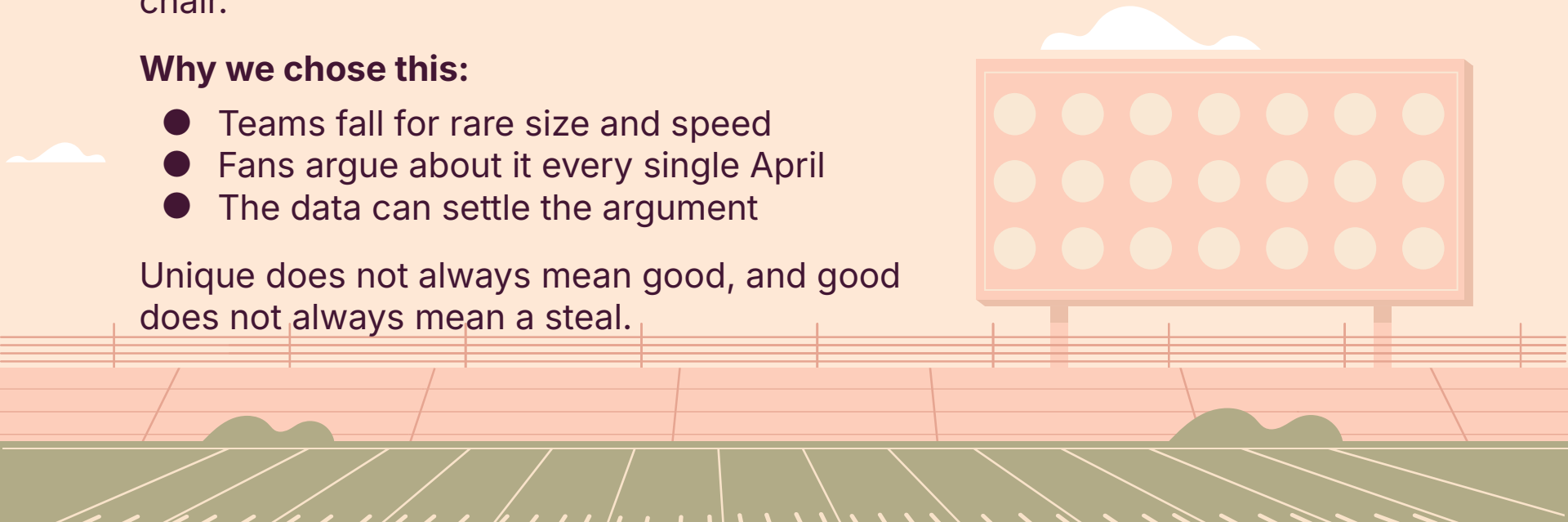
Do unique players pay off?

We watch the NFL Draft every year, but it is hard to tell how good a pick really is. As fantasy football managers, we want to sit in the GM's chair.

Why we chose this:

- Teams fall for rare size and speed
- Fans argue about it every single April
- The data can settle the argument

Unique does not always mean good, and good does not always mean a steal.



How we will test it

1. COLLECT

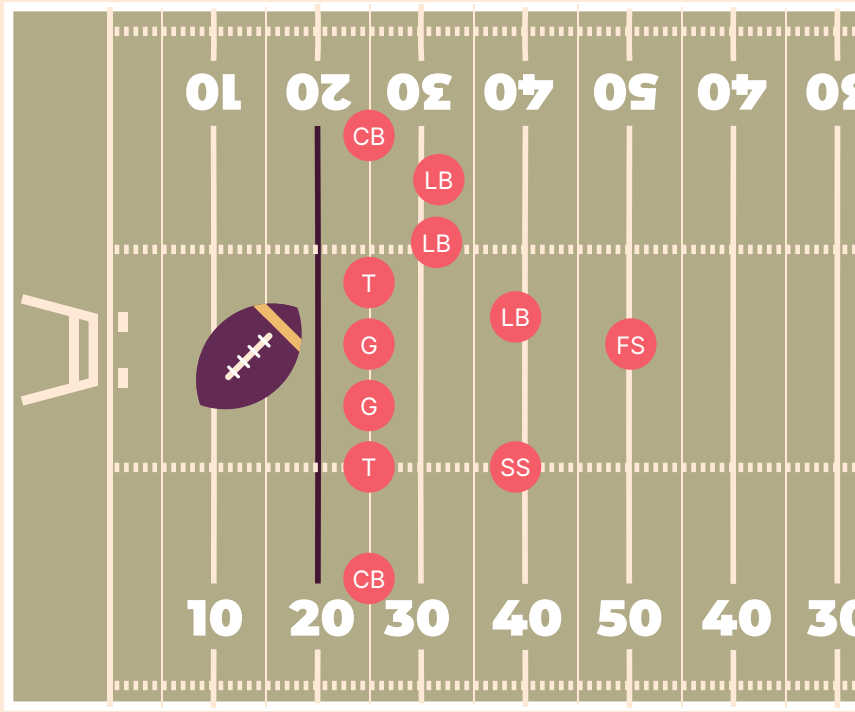
NFL Combine measurements and draft results, pulled from the open nflverse project

2. DETECT

Unsupervised models: Isolation Forest, Local Outlier Factor, Mahalanobis distance

3. GRADE

Compare each career to what that pick usually returns



What we hope to find out

Unique or good?

Do unusual athletes have better careers than typical ones?

The price

Do teams spend earlier picks on rare athletes?

Steal or bust?

Do they beat what their draft slot normally returns?

By position

Where does being different help the most?

By round

Are unique players safer bets early or late?

The payoff

A simple guide to when a unique player is worth the pick

Appendix: preliminary results

7,690

prospects in our data so far, from the 2000 to 2026 combines

390

flagged as unusual, the top 5% at their position

108

of those are true athletic standouts

88% vs 67%

share drafted, standouts vs typical prospects

Pick 66 vs 109

median draft slot, standouts vs typical prospects

37% vs 18%

round one steal rate, standouts vs typical. Will it hold up?